DIGITALAIKART

Amazon KDP Self-Publishing Playbook

India Edition 2026-27

Publish a book. Get paid in rupees.
The honest, complete guide for Indian authors.

Royalties | Tax | ISBN | Publishing | Launch

Every rule verified from kdp.amazon.com and the Income-tax Act, 2025

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A note on how this was written

Every royalty rate, fee, tax rule, deadline and policy quoted in this playbook was checked against an official source: Amazon's own KDP Help Centre, the Income-tax Act 2025 as published by the Income Tax Department, the Raja Rammohun Roy National Agency for ISBN, and the GST law. Figures carry their date. Where a number moves often (exchange rates, the Kindle Unlimited per-page rate, title limits), the playbook says so and tells you where to confirm the live figure.

This is a guide, not tax or legal advice. Tax law depends on your own facts. Before you file, speak to a chartered accountant.

How to use this playbook

This playbook answers one question: how does an ordinary person in India put a book on sale on Amazon and get paid for it, without losing money to a rule they did not know about? It is written for the writer who has never published, the professional who wants a second income, and the small business owner who wants a lead magnet that also earns.

Read it in order the first time. The chapters are sequenced the way the decisions actually arrive: first whether KDP makes sense for you, then the money, then the tax, then the book itself, then the launch. Chapters 2, 3 and 10 are the ones people skip and later regret, because they decide whether a sale leaves you Rs. 30 or Rs. 240. If you are in a hurry, read those three and then come back.

Three habits will get the most out of this book:

- **Verify the live number.** Royalty bands, the Kindle Unlimited per-page rate, title limits and tax forms change. This playbook tells you where each figure lives so you can check it in two minutes before it costs you.
- **Do the maths on paper first.** Every pricing chapter here ends in arithmetic. Run your own numbers before you upload, not after your first ten sales.
- **Treat it as a business, not a lottery.** One book rarely changes an income. A small catalogue of books that each sell a few copies a month does. The maths in Chapter 2 shows exactly why.

What this playbook is not

It is not a promise of income. Most first books earn little. What the book gives you is the full rulebook and the honest arithmetic, so that whatever you earn, you keep the most of it and you do not lose the account you built it on.

Chapter 1

Why KDP is the most reliable rupee-to-dollar path from home

Kindle Direct Publishing is the only mainstream route by which an individual in India, with no company, no inventory, no employees and no GST registration, can put a finished work on sale to readers in India and across the world and receive the money directly into an Indian bank account. That sentence is the whole case for KDP, and it is worth understanding precisely, because every other option asks for something more.

What KDP actually is

KDP is Amazon's self-service publishing platform. You upload a manuscript and a cover, fill in a listing, set a price, and Amazon sells the book on its Kindle stores and, in supported markets, as print-on-demand paperbacks and hardcovers. Publishing costs nothing up front. There is no inventory and no printing bill: for eBooks the file is delivered digitally, and for print the cost of printing is deducted from each sale. Amazon pays you a royalty out of each sale, on a schedule, to the bank account you register.

For an Indian author, four things follow from that design, and they are the reasons this route is worth your time:

- **No gatekeeper.** No agent, no publisher, no advance to negotiate. You decide to publish and you publish.
- **Global reach from one upload.** The same file sells on Amazon.in, Amazon.com, Amazon.co.uk and the other Kindle stores. An English book reaches readers who pay far more per copy than the Indian market does.
- **No company required.** You can start as an individual using your own PAN and bank account. A company, a GST number and a chartered accountant are questions for later, once there is income worth structuring.
- **Payment in rupees.** Amazon pays Indian authors by direct bank transfer to an Indian account. No foreign account, no PayPal, no intermediary.

The honest scale of it

Now the part the marketing skips. A single first book, marketed to nobody, typically sells a handful of copies. Realistic first-year income for a consistent beginner is pocket money, not a salary. That is not a reason to avoid KDP; it is a reason to understand how the income is actually built. It compounds through a catalogue, and the arithmetic is simple:

The only formula that matters

Monthly royalty income = number of books x average sales per book per month x royalty per sale.

None of the three terms has to be large. A catalogue of 12 books, each selling 5 copies a month at roughly Rs. 140 of royalty per sale, is about Rs. 8,400 a month. The same 12 books at 15 copies each is about Rs. 25,000 a month. The lever you control most directly is the number of books, because a book that sells keeps selling while you write the next one.

This is why the playbook pushes you towards a series or a set of related books rather than one perfect volume. It is also why Chapter 2 comes before Chapter 7: if a sale nets you Rs. 30 instead of Rs. 200 because of a pricing mistake, no amount of good writing fixes the arithmetic.

What KDP is not

- **Not passive.** Books need a listing that sells, a cover that competes, and often advertising. The work shifts from writing to publishing and marketing; it does not disappear.
- **Not instant.** KDP reviews a new title before it goes live, and royalty payments arrive roughly two months after the month in which the sale happened.
- **Not a place for shortcuts.** Copying other people's work, stuffing keywords, buying reviews or republishing thin content gets an account suspended, and a suspended account takes every book and every royalty stream with it. Chapter 12 is devoted to staying on the right side of that line.

Who this playbook is for

It is written for the Indian author who wants to publish in English for the world market, for the author who wants to publish in Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Malayalam or Gujarati for Indian readers, and for the professional or business owner who wants a book that builds credibility and also earns. If you are any of those, the next chapter is the most valuable page in the book.

Chapter 2

The royalty maths in rupees, before you price anything

An Indian author keeps far less per sale than most people assume, because four separate deductions stand between the price a reader pays and the money in your account. Get these four right and a Rs. 199 eBook can pay you roughly Rs. 97. Get them wrong and the same book pays you Rs. 26. This chapter is the difference.

The four things taken out of every Indian sale

- **GST, 18%, inside the price.** On Amazon.in the list price you set already includes 18% GST. KDP deducts that GST before it calculates your royalty. A Rs. 199 price contains about Rs. 30 of GST, so your royalty is worked out on about Rs. 169, not Rs. 199.
- **Delivery cost, Rs. 7 per MB.** If you choose the 70% royalty option, KDP deducts a delivery cost based on your file size. On Amazon.in that is Rs. 7 per megabyte, with a minimum of Rs. 1. A lean file matters here: a 2 MB book costs you Rs. 14 per sale, a 10 MB book costs Rs. 70.
- **The royalty rate, 70% or 35%.** You choose one per book. 70% is available only inside a price band and, in India, only if the book is in KDP Select. Outside those conditions you drop to 35%.
- **Withholding tax.** Amazon.in royalty payments are subject to 10% Singaporean withholding for publishers who are not based in Singapore, and Indian authors are generally not eligible for a reduced rate. Sales on Amazon.com carry 15% US withholding under the India-US treaty (Chapter 3).

The India royalty band, and the KDP Select catch

The 70% option for the India store applies only to eBooks priced between Rs. 99 and Rs. 599. Price below Rs. 99 or above Rs. 599 and you earn 35%. The catch that almost nobody quotes: for sales to readers in India, Brazil, Japan and Mexico, a book must also be enrolled in KDP Select to earn the 70% rate. KDP Select is Amazon's exclusivity programme, so in India the real choice is not 70% versus 35%; it is 70% with exclusivity versus 35% without. Chapter 10 walks through when each choice is right.

India Kindle store - eBook list price	Royalty option	Notes
Rs. 49 - Rs. 98 (file under 3 MB)	35% only	Below the 70% band
Rs. 99 - Rs. 599	70% if in KDP Select, else 35%	The band you want to price inside
Rs. 600 - Rs. 10,999	35% only	Above the 70% band

Source: KDP eBook List Price Requirements, kdp.amazon.com. Band shown includes GST.

The royalty formula, and three worked examples

For the 70% option, royalty = 70% x (list price - GST - delivery cost). For the 35% option, royalty = 35% x (list price - GST). Then withholding is applied to what Amazon pays out. Here is what that means in rupees, using a 2 MB file and, for the dollar example, an illustrative exchange rate of Rs. 88 per US dollar.

Scenario	Price	GST out	Delivery	Royalty	Withholding	You keep
Amazon.in, 70%, in KDP Select	Rs. 199	Rs. 30	Rs. 14	Rs. 108	10% (SG)	**~Rs. 97**

Scenario	Price	GST out	Delivery	Royalty	Withholding	You keep
Amazon.in, 35%, not in Select	Rs. 99	Rs. 15	n/a	Rs. 29	10% (SG)	**~Rs. 26**
Amazon.com, 70%, $4.99	$4.99	n/a	$0.30	$3.28	15% (US)	**~$2.79 (Rs. 245)**

Illustrative arithmetic only. Exchange rates move; confirm your own numbers in KDP before publishing. GST is calculated at 18% inside the list price (price x 18/118).

The lesson is on the second and third rows. A Rs. 99 book outside KDP Select pays you about a quarter of what a Rs. 199 book inside it pays, for the same amount of writing. And a single sale in the United States can pay more than two and a half sales in India, which is why an English book aimed at global readers is the highest-value thing most Indian authors can publish.

Kindle Unlimited: paid by the page, and India is cheap

Enrol in KDP Select and your book also enters Kindle Unlimited, Amazon's subscription library. Here you are not paid per sale but per page read, once, the first time a subscriber reads it, capped at 3,000 pages per title per customer. The rate is not fixed: each month Amazon announces a global fund and divides it across all pages read, so the per-page rate floats.

- In the United States, the per-page rate has recently sat around USD 0.005, so a full read of a 300-page book pays roughly USD 1.5 (about Rs. 130).
- In India, the per-page rate has recently sat around Rs. 0.07, so the same 300-page full read pays only about Rs. 21.
- The practical conclusion: for an Indian author, Kindle Unlimited is valuable mainly for discovery and for readers outside India. Do not count on KU page reads from Indian subscribers to fund anything.

Rates quoted are the most recent tracked figures (September 2026); KDP does not publish a universal per-page rate, so confirm the current month's rate in your own KDP reports.

Armed with this arithmetic, you can now see why the rest of the book is ordered the way it is: tax next, because withholding and Indian tax interact, and pricing later, because it is a decision you make once you understand both.

Chapter 3

The India tax picture you cannot skip

KDP income touches two tax systems at once. The United States withholds tax before Amazon pays you, and India taxes the same income because you are resident here. Handled well, the two dovetail and you are not taxed twice, and an Indian provision can shield up to Rs. 3,00,000 of royalty income from tax entirely. Handled badly, you lose 30% to the US instead of 15%, and you forget a form that would have saved you the tax. This chapter is the map.

Step one: reduce the US withholding from 30% to 15%

Amazon will not let a non-US person publish until they complete a tax profile. If you complete it without claiming a treaty benefit, Amazon withholds 30% of the royalties it treats as US-source income: eBook sales on Amazon.com, and print sales on Amazon.com, Amazon.co.jp, Amazon.com.au and Amazon.ca, including your share of the Kindle Unlimited fund. India and the United States have a tax treaty, and under Article 12 the rate on copyright royalties for a literary work is 15%. To claim it, complete the tax interview in your KDP account, choose India as your country of residence, claim treaty benefits, and give your tax identification number, which for an individual in India is your PAN.

The form and its expiry date

The tax interview produces a Form W-8BEN electronically. It is valid only until the last day of the third calendar year after you sign it. If it expires while you are on the reduced rate, Amazon reverts you to 30% until you redo the interview. Diarise the expiry, or you will silently lose 15% of every US sale.

Step two: the two other withholdings nobody mentions

Where the sale happened	Who withholds	Rate	Who it applies to
Amazon.com (eBook and print)	US (IRS)	15% with treaty, else 30%	Indian authors, after W-8BEN
Amazon.in	Singapore	10%	Non-Singapore publishers, incl. India
Amazon.com.br	Brazil	15%	All publishers

Source: KDP Tax Withholding, kdp.amazon.com. The W-8BEN does nothing about the Singapore or Brazil withholding.

Step three: Indian tax, and the Rs. 3,00,000 author deduction

If you are a resident and ordinarily resident in India, your KDP royalty is taxable in India because India taxes the worldwide income of its residents. It is business or professional income, and you can claim your expenses against it. On top of that, the Income-tax Act, 2025 contains a provision written specifically for authors. Section 151 (it was Section 80QQB under the old Act, and it carries over unchanged in substance) allows a resident individual author a deduction from royalty or copyright income on a book that is literary, artistic or scientific.

Section 151, Income-tax Act 2025 - the author deduction	Detail
Who can claim it	A resident individual author (not a firm or company)
How much	The royalty income, or Rs. 3,00,000, whichever is less

Section 151, Income-tax Act 2025 - the author deduction	Detail
The 15% ceiling	Where the royalty is not a lump sum, income above 15% of the value of books sold that year is ignored for the deduction
Foreign-source income	Counted only if brought into India in convertible foreign exchange within six months of the end of the tax year
The form you must file	Form 36 (Rule 70 of the Income-tax Rules, 2026), filed electronically, self-verified by you and certified by the publisher
What a 'book' excludes	Brochures, commentaries, diaries, guides, journals, magazines, newspapers, pamphlets, school textbooks and tracts

Source: Income-tax Act 2025, Section 151; Form 36 guidance note, incometaxindia.gov.in.

Two cautions. First, the Section 151 deduction is available only under the old tax regime; check your own position with a chartered accountant, because the choice of regime can change the answer. Second, notice the exclusion list: if you write a short guide, a journal or a diary, it does not qualify as a 'book' for this deduction. A full-length work of literary, artistic or scientific writing does. This is one more reason to aim for a real book rather than a thin low-content file.

Step four: do not be taxed twice - the foreign tax credit

The US tax Amazon withholds is not a cost; it is a credit. Under Article 25 of the India-US treaty, India gives you credit for tax already paid in the United States on the same income. You claim it by filing Form 67 with the Income Tax Department along with your return. Note one thing that surprises people: the income you declare in India is the gross royalty, not the amount left after US withholding, because the withheld tax is not an expense.

Step five: GST - usually nothing, until it is something

Most Indian authors worry about GST unnecessarily at the start. Here is the working position:

- **Sales outside India (Amazon.com, Amazon.co.uk and the rest) are exports of services and are zero-rated.** No GST is charged on them regardless of how much you earn.
- **Sales on Amazon.in are domestic supplies.** GST at 18% applies once your aggregate turnover in India crosses Rs. 20 lakh in a financial year. Below that threshold, an individual author generally does not need to register.
- **Track the two separately.** Only your Amazon.in sales count towards the Rs. 20 lakh threshold. If you cross it, register and charge GST on the Indian sales only.

This is a working summary, not advice. GST and income-tax positions depend on your facts, and the interaction of royalty income with GST is one of the areas where a chartered accountant earns their fee. Engage one before your first significant payout, not after.

Chapter 4

Getting paid in rupees, month after month

The publishing is free; the payment is where beginners lose time. KDP pays Indian authors by direct bank transfer, but only after you have entered your bank details, completed the tax profile and crossed a minimum threshold. Set this up once, correctly, and the money arrives on schedule without further effort.

Setting up payment

- In your KDP account, go to Account, then Getting Paid, and choose bank transfer (EFT) as your payment method.
- Enter your account holder name exactly as it appears on the bank account, your account number, your bank name and the IFSC code. A mismatch between the name on the account and your KDP details is the most common reason a payment fails.
- Complete the tax interview (Chapter 3) - it is mandatory before you can publish, and it decides your withholding rate.
- Give your PAN as your tax identification number so the 15% treaty rate applies to US-source royalties.

KDP does not pay by PayPal for Indian accounts, and you do not need a foreign bank account. Rupee royalties from Amazon.in, and dollar royalties from the other stores, are converted and paid to the same Indian account.

When the money arrives

- **The schedule.** KDP pays royalties on a standard cycle of roughly 60 days after the end of the month in which the sale was recorded. A sale in January is typically paid in late March.
- **The threshold.** Royalties accumulate in your KDP account until they reach the minimum payout threshold, currently USD 100 for bank transfer. Small early months may roll over until the threshold is crossed.
- **The conversion.** Dollar royalties are converted to rupees at the rate applied when the payment is made, not when the sale happened.
- **The statement.** Each year KDP issues a Form 1042-S showing the US-source royalties and the tax withheld - the document you use to claim your foreign tax credit in India.

Threshold and timing figures are KDP's standard published practice; confirm the current numbers in your own KDP account, as Amazon adjusts them from time to time.

Keeping records that a chartered accountant will thank you for

- Download your KDP royalty reports every month and keep them. They are your income record.
- Keep the Form 1042-S each year for the foreign tax credit.
- Keep every bank credit advice for foreign inward remittance; the FIRC (Foreign Inward Remittance Certificate) is the proof you may need for the Section 151 foreign-income condition and for GST export treatment.
- Keep a simple spreadsheet: month, gross royalty by store, withholding, net received. Five minutes a month now saves a week at filing time.

The single most useful habit

Open a separate bank account, or at least a separate ledger, for KDP income from day one. Mixing royalty income into your personal account makes the tax return harder, the expense claim weaker and the GST threshold impossible to track.

Chapter 5

The ISBN decision: free KDP ISBN or free Indian ISBN

An ISBN is the thirteen-digit number that identifies your book to the book trade. You do not need to buy one, and you almost certainly do not need to pay anyone for one. You have two free options, and which you choose depends on whether you ever want to sell the book outside Amazon.

Option one: the free KDP ISBN

When you set up a book, KDP offers a free ISBN. Take it and you can publish in minutes. The trade-off is that Amazon becomes the publisher of record for that edition. That is fine while the book lives only on Amazon. It becomes a problem if you later want the same book in Indian bookshops, libraries or another retailer, because an ISBN identifies a title and edition for life and cannot be reassigned. You would need to publish a new edition under a new ISBN.

Option two: the free Indian ISBN

The Raja Rammohun Roy National Agency (RRRNA), under the Ministry of Education, issues ISBNs to publishers and self-publishing authors based in India, and it issues them free of cost. An individual author who self-publishes from India applies in the 'Individual author' category. The agency's own guidance is clear on the points that matter:

- It is free. There is no charge for an ISBN from RRRNA.
- A self-publishing individual author is allotted a single ISBN at a time; when you have used it, you apply for the next.
- Each format needs its own ISBN: an eBook, a paperback and a hardcover of the same title are three different products.
- The whole process normally takes about 7 to 9 working days across its approval stages, subject to the volume of applications.
- You cannot change the title, the publisher name or the author name after the ISBN is issued, so settle those first.
- The agency does not provide the barcode; your printer or a barcode provider does that.
- You must upload the cover page and the title-verso page after the ISBN is issued, or the book stays pending in the register.

Apply at isbn.gov.in. The agency sits at the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, Jeevan Deep Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi.

Which should you choose?

Your situation	Use	Why
Publishing only on Amazon Kindle, now	KDP ISBN	Instant, free, and nothing else needs it
You may sell print in India, or on other retailers later	RRRNA ISBN	You own the publisher record; the ISBN stays with you
A paperback or hardcover in a supported print market	Either, but a separate ISBN per format	Each format is a distinct product
Low-content books (journals, planners)	KDP lets you publish without an ISBN	Check KDP's low-content rules before you do

There is one more fact that decides a lot for Indian authors: KDP does not support paperback or hardcover distribution on Amazon.in. If your plan is a printed book sold to Indian readers, KDP is not the route for the print edition - you will need an Indian printer and an Indian ISBN. If your plan is an eBook, and especially an English eBook sold worldwide, the KDP ISBN is enough to start.

Chapter 6

Choosing a niche that actually sells in 2026

The most common reason a well-written book earns nothing is that it was written for a reader who does not shop on Amazon. Choosing the niche is the decision that matters most, and it can be researched in an afternoon rather than guessed.

Start from demand, not from the book

The instinct is to write the book you want to write. The better method is to find a category where readers already buy, then write the book those readers are looking for. Amazon gives you the research tools for free, and they are open to anyone.

- **Bestseller ranks tell you velocity.** A book ranked in the low thousands in its category is selling steadily. A category whose top twenty titles are all ranked above 100,000 is a category where nobody is buying.
- **Search suggestions reveal language.** Type your topic into Amazon's search box and read the autocomplete list. Those are the exact phrases readers type. They become your keywords later.
- **Reviews reveal gaps.** Read the one-star and two-star reviews of the current bestsellers in your niche. Every repeated complaint - 'too basic', 'nothing for Indian readers', 'no templates' - is a gap you can fill.
- **Also-bought maps the shelf.** The 'customers also bought' strip on a bestseller shows you the exact books your reader compares you against. That is your competition, and your cover must look like it belongs on the same shelf.

The two markets available to an Indian author

You have a genuine choice that authors in smaller markets do not, and it changes everything about the book you write.

Market	Who reads	The trade-off
Global English	Readers on Amazon.com, .co.uk and the other stores	Far higher royalty per sale, far more competition, and your book must match international expectations of length and polish
Indian English	Readers on Amazon.in	Less competition and a lower price point, but the 70% band tops out at Rs. 599 and Indian per-sale royalties are small
Indian languages	Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Malayalam, Gujarati readers	KDP supports these for eBooks (Kindle Create covers them), the competition is thin, and you reach readers nobody else is serving

Source: KDP supported languages, kdp.amazon.com. Print publishing for these Indian languages is not available through KDP.

What to avoid

- **Companion and summary books based on someone else's work.** KDP does not allow study guides or summaries of copyrighted books outside the US without the rights holder's written permission, and it removes them.
- **Repackaged public domain text.** Books made mainly of public domain content are eligible only for the 35% royalty option, and they are exactly the kind of thin listing Amazon is tightening against.
- **Thin low-content files dressed as books.** A few lined pages with a keyword-stuffed title is the pattern that gets accounts suspended. If you publish journals or planners, follow KDP's low-content rules and do not pretend they are something else.

- **A single book with no follow-on.** The catalogue maths in Chapter 2 only works if there is more than one book.

A five-minute niche scorecard

Score any candidate niche out of ten on each line. A niche that does not score at least 30 is not worth a month of writing.

Test	What a good score looks like
Demand	The top sellers in the category rank inside the low thousands, not the hundreds of thousands
Gap	The current bestsellers have repeated complaints you can answer
Language fit	You can write it naturally, in the language your reader searches in
Series potential	You can see three or four more books for the same reader
Honest value	You would pay for this book yourself

Chapter 7

Writing the book, and the AI rules you must respect

AI has changed how fast a book can be produced, and Amazon has responded with a disclosure rule that is simple on its face and easy to get wrong. Getting it wrong does not mean a warning; it means removal of the title or suspension of the account. This chapter states the rule exactly and then sets the quality bar that keeps a book on sale.

The disclosure rule, in Amazon's own distinction

KDP requires you to tell it about AI-generated content - text, images or translations - when you publish a new book or when you edit and republish an existing one. It does not require you to disclose AI-assisted content. The line between the two is who created the content, not how much you edited it afterwards.

How you used AI	Amazon's label	Disclose?
An AI tool wrote a chapter, even if you rewrote it heavily	AI-generated	Yes
An AI tool created the cover art or interior illustrations	AI-generated	Yes
An AI tool translated your manuscript	AI-generated	Yes
You wrote the book; AI checked grammar or tightened sentences	AI-assisted	No
You wrote the book; AI helped you brainstorm ideas or an outline	AI-assisted	No

Source: KDP Content Guidelines, AI content section, kdp.amazon.com. The disclosure is internal to Amazon and is not shown on your product page.

The practical reading is this. If a machine produced the words or the pictures that end up in the file, declare it, however much you then edited. If you produced them and a machine only polished, you do not. When in doubt, declare; the disclosure itself costs you nothing and carries no ranking penalty that Amazon has documented. Failing to declare is what carries the risk.

The quality bar: 'poor customer experience'

Disclosure is only half the compliance. KDP also removes books that create a poor customer experience, and its guidance names the patterns: content that misleads, and content that is typically disappointing - very short books, repetitive books, poorly translated books, and books that are near-identical to others. A rushed AI-generated file that is technically disclosed still fails this test if it is thin. The answer is not to avoid AI; it is to make the book genuinely good.

- Aim for a real book length for your genre. A serious non-fiction title runs to tens of thousands of words; a novel more. A 3,000-word file is a pamphlet and reads like one.
- Edit for a reader, not for a word count. Cut repetition; every chapter should carry something the others do not.
- If you translate, use a human reviewer. Machine translation that nobody checked is the single most common trigger of a removal.
- Make the cover and description honest. A listing that promises more than the file delivers is a removal waiting to happen.

Working with AI the safe way

Used properly, AI is a research assistant, an editor and a structural critic, not an author. The workflow that keeps you compliant and produces a better book is: you choose the niche and the promise; you outline; you draft, using AI to research and to argue with you; you edit; you use AI to proofread and to pressure-test the structure; and you disclose anything a machine actually wrote. That keeps the book your own and keeps the account safe.

One more rule worth knowing

KDP limits how many new titles you can create and submit each week, per format. The cap has been tightened over time. If you plan to publish a catalogue, confirm the current limit inside your KDP account before you plan your schedule, so a weekly cap does not quietly stall you.

Chapter 8

Production: files, tools and a cover that meets spec

Production is the least glamorous chapter and the one that most often blocks a launch. A manuscript in the wrong format, or a cover one pixel off spec, is rejected by KDP's automated review and returned to you with a delay. Everything here is a specification, not an opinion.

The manuscript

KDP accepts a range of formats and converts them to Kindle editions. The most reliable path for a text-heavy book is Microsoft Word (DOC or DOCX), or the Kindle Package Format (KPF) produced by Amazon's own free Kindle Create tool.

Format	When to use it
DOC / DOCX	The simplest path. Most Word files convert well; complex layout may not
KPF (via Kindle Create)	Best for avoiding formatting problems; handles typesetting, TOC and themes for you
EPUB	Accepted if it meets the Kindle Publishing Guidelines; validate it before upload
HTML, RTF, TXT	Accepted for simple text
PDF	Accepted only in certain languages; not ideal for reflowable books
MOBI	No longer accepted for fixed-layout eBooks since March 2025

Source: KDP supported manuscript formats, kdp.amazon.com.

A few production habits prevent the most common quality flags: apply a heading style to every chapter title so the table of contents builds correctly; use a single paragraph-indent style rather than tab spaces; turn off track changes; do not include the cover image inside the manuscript (you upload it separately); and do not add page numbers or headers, because eBooks reflow and those do not apply. After you upload, KDP converts the file in about five to seven minutes, and you can preview it on phone, tablet and e-reader before you publish.

The cover, to the pixel

The cover is the single biggest driver of whether a browsing reader clicks, and it has a hard specification.

Cover specification	Requirement
Format	JPEG (.jpg) or TIFF (.tif)
Ideal dimensions	1,600 pixels wide x 2,560 pixels high
Minimum dimensions	625 wide x 1,000 high; maximum 10,000 in either direction
Aspect ratio	At least 1.6 : 1 (height to width)
Colour	RGB, no colour separation
Resolution	72 dpi as supplied; aim for at least 300 PPI source
File size	Under 50 MB

Source: KDP eBook cover image criteria, kdp.amazon.com.

Two practical notes. Keep the title large enough to read as a thumbnail, because that is how most buyers first see it. And if your cover has a white or very light background, add a thin grey border, or it will disappear against Amazon's white page.

Front matter, back matter and the TOC

A clean book has a title page, an optional dedication and a copyright page at the front, and an about-the-author page and a bibliography at the back. The table of contents should be built from your chapter headings, not typed by hand. Kindle Create does this automatically and adds an interactive contents list. Get the front matter right once and reuse the template for every book in your catalogue - it is one of the few places where a template genuinely saves time.

Pre-upload checklist

Title, subtitle and author name in the file match what you enter in KDP. | Heading styles applied to chapter titles. | Track changes off. | Cover uploaded separately, meeting spec. | Previewed on phone, tablet and e-reader. | AI-generated content identified, so you can answer the disclosure question honestly.

Chapter 9

Metadata that sells: title, keywords, categories, description

Metadata is everything on the listing that is not the book: the title, the subtitle, the seven keyword boxes, the three categories and the description. It is how readers who have never heard of you find you, and Amazon enforces rules on every part of it. Fill it well and honestly, and a good book becomes discoverable. Fill it with tricks, and the listing is suppressed.

Title and subtitle

The title and subtitle together must stay under 200 characters. Put the promise in the title and the specific audience or outcome in the subtitle - for example, a title naming the subject and a subtitle naming the reader. Do not stuff keywords into the title; KDP prohibits HTML tags in the title and subtitle fields, and a keyword-stuffed title reads as spam to the reader who is deciding whether to click.

Seven keywords

Each format gets up to seven keyword boxes, one word or short phrase each. KDP recommends phrases of two to three words. This is where the autocomplete research from Chapter 6 pays off.

- **Use the phrases readers actually type**, in the order they type them. 'Military science fiction', not 'fiction science military'.
- **Do not repeat your title, subtitle or category words.** Keywords should add the setting, the reader, the theme or the tone that the rest of the listing cannot carry.
- **Search each candidate keyword on Amazon before you publish.** If the results are irrelevant, the keyword is wrong.
- **Never use** another author's name, another book's title, a sales-rank claim such as 'bestselling', promotional words such as 'free', or anything unrelated to what is inside.

Three categories

You choose up to three categories per format from Amazon's list, based on your primary audience and marketplace. Choose the ones that genuinely describe the book. Amazon removes or changes categories it considers unrelated, and it has a zero-tolerance policy for categories chosen to mislead. Categories are also slow to update - a new category can take up to 72 hours to appear.

The description, and what is banned from it

You get up to 4,000 characters, and HTML tags count towards that total. A short, scannable description that opens with a hook, states the promise and names the reader outperforms a wall of text. KDP's own advice is to describe the main plot, theme or idea and to keep it easy to scan.

KDP will not accept any of the following in a description, and a listing that contains them can be blocked:

- Phone numbers, physical addresses, email addresses or website URLs.
- Reviews, quotes or testimonials, or requests for customer reviews.
- Advertisements, watermarks or promotional material.
- Time-sensitive information such as tour dates or event dates.
- Availability, price or alternative ordering information.

- Spoilers, emojis, or a list of keywords.

A small but useful extra: Amazon's Author Central and the A+ content tools let you add a richer, image-led section to your book page. They are optional, but for a serious catalogue they are worth setting up once the book is live.

Chapter 10

Pricing for India and for the world

Price is not a moral question; it is arithmetic. The right price is the one that maximises what you keep, given the royalty band, the withholding and the market you are selling into. This chapter turns the maths from Chapter 2 into a decision.

The band decides your India price

For the India store, the 70% rate applies only between Rs. 99 and Rs. 599, and only if the book is in KDP Select. Inside that band, royalty rises roughly in line with price. At Rs. 99 you keep about Rs. 26; at Rs. 199 you keep about Rs. 97; at Rs. 299 you keep about Rs. 160. For most Indian eBooks, Rs. 199 to Rs. 299 is the sweet spot: low enough to be an easy yes, high enough that the royalty is worth having.

India price (70%, in Select, 2 MB file)	Approx. royalty after 10% withholding
Rs. 99	~Rs. 26
Rs. 149	~Rs. 65
Rs. 199	~Rs. 97
Rs. 299	~Rs. 160
Rs. 499	~Rs. 288
Rs. 599	~Rs. 350

Illustrative, at 18% GST inside the price and Rs. 7/MB delivery. Your own numbers depend on file size and the current rate.

The KDP Select trade-off

KDP Select is a free 90-day enrolment, renewable. It gives you the 70% rate in India, entry into Kindle Unlimited, and two promotional tools: a Free Book Promotion and a Kindle Countdown Deal. In exchange, the digital edition must be exclusive to Amazon for the term - you cannot sell the eBook anywhere else, including your own website. Because India's 70% rate requires Select, an Indian author who wants the higher rate is, in practice, choosing exclusivity. The question is whether you would sell enough copies elsewhere to beat what Select pays you. For most beginners, the answer is no, and Select is the right starting choice.

Pricing across the world

Your book sells on several stores at once, and each store has its own currency and its own 70% band. Do not let KDP convert your US price into the others blindly; set each store's price by hand so it sits inside that store's band. The US band for the 70% option runs from USD 2.99 to USD 12.99. An English book priced at USD 4.99 earns you roughly USD 2.79 per sale after the 15% withholding - several times an Indian sale. This is the single strongest argument for writing in English and for the global market, even though your home market is India.

Paperbacks, and the Indian reality

KDP supports paperback and hardcover publishing in supported print markets, but Amazon.in is not one of them: KDP does not distribute paperbacks or hardcovers on the India store. An Indian reader who wants your print book cannot buy it through KDP on Amazon.in. If a printed edition matters to you, plan for it separately - an Indian printer and an Indian ISBN - and treat the eBook as your main product for now. Do not build a launch around a print edition that Indian readers cannot actually buy.

A pricing rule of thumb

Price inside the 70% band, in KDP Select, with a lean file. At Rs. 199 in India and USD 4.99 in the US, a single book pays you roughly Rs. 97 at home and about Rs. 245 abroad. Then write the next one - the catalogue, not the single price, is what builds the income.

Chapter 11

Launch and visibility without breaking the rules

A published book is not a found book. Amazon shows a new title to almost nobody until it starts selling, so the launch is about giving it an honest first push that earns the visibility that follows. Every tool in this chapter is one Amazon provides; none of them requires a trick.

Use the tools KDP Select gives you

- **Free Book Promotion.** You can make the eBook free for up to five days within each 90-day Select term. Free downloads do not earn royalty, but they can lift a book's rank and gather reviews that help later paid sales.
- **Kindle Countdown Deals.** A time-limited discount with a countdown clock. Note that KDP runs Countdown Deals only on Amazon.com and Amazon.co.uk, not on Amazon.in, so its value for Indian readers is limited.
- **Category and keyword iteration.** You can change your seven keywords and three categories at any time. If a book is not being found, that is the first thing to test.

Advertising, honestly

Amazon's own ad platform lets you bid to place your book in front of shoppers searching for terms related to your niche. The one number that matters is whether each sale costs you less than the royalty it earns. If a sale pays you Rs. 97, an ad that costs Rs. 60 to produce a sale is profitable; one that costs Rs. 120 is not. Start with a small daily budget, watch that number, and cut the keywords that lose money. Amazon ads are available in several marketplaces, including India and the United States.

Reviews: the rules that protect you

Reviews drive sales, and the fastest way to lose an account is to chase them wrongly. What is not allowed: paying for reviews, swapping reviews with other authors, offering anything in return for a review, reviewing your own books or those of family, and putting review requests or testimonials in your book description. What is allowed: telling readers honestly, in your back matter, that a review helps; running a free promotion to reach more readers; and letting reviews accumulate naturally. Amazon removes reviews it links to a review group, and it can suspend accounts that manipulate them.

The ad maths, worked

Say a click on your ad costs Rs. 12 and one in eight clicks becomes a sale. That is Rs. 96 of ad spend per sale. If a sale pays you about Rs. 97 after withholding, the campaign is roughly break-even on royalty alone and worth running only because it also lifts rank and gathers reviews. If a click costs Rs. 20 and one in ten becomes a sale, that is Rs. 200 per sale against Rs. 97 of royalty, and you are paying to lose money. Two numbers decide everything: your cost per click, and your clicks per sale. Track both from the first rupee you spend.

A realistic launch sequence

- Before publishing: finalise the listing, the cover and the keywords, and set the price inside the band.
- Week one: run a short free promotion or a Countdown Deal where available, and tell whatever audience you have.
- Weeks two to four: turn on a small ad campaign for your best keywords, and watch cost per sale.
- Month two onwards: leave the book running, and start the next one. The catalogue is the strategy.

Do not expect a launch to make a book sell. Expect a launch to give a good book its first honest chance, and then let the catalogue do the compounding.

Chapter 12

Protecting your KDP account

Your KDP account is the asset. Every book, every royalty stream and every reader relationship sits behind one login, and Amazon can suspend an account for a single serious breach. The rules in this chapter are the ones that actually get accounts closed, stated plainly so you never have to find out the hard way.

The content rules that matter

- **No copyright or trademark violations.** Do not publish content you do not own, and do not use characters, brands or images you have no right to. Companion books, summaries and study guides based on copyrighted works are not allowed outside the US without written permission.
- **Disclose AI-generated content.** Text, images and translations created by an AI tool must be declared, even after heavy editing. Undeclared AI-generated content violates the guidelines.
- **No misleading metadata.** Keywords and categories must describe what is inside. KDP has a zero-tolerance policy for metadata meant to advertise, promote or mislead.
- **No disappointing content.** Very short, repetitive, poorly translated or near-identical books are removable.
- **Respect the title limits.** KDP caps how many new titles you can create and submit per week, per format. Confirm the current figure in your account.

The behaviours that quietly endanger an account

- Buying, swapping or incentivising reviews.
- Running more than one KDP account to manipulate rankings.
- Keyword-stuffing or claiming to be a different author.
- Republishing the same content as several near-identical books.
- Ignoring an email from KDP about a title; a prompt response to a notice often resolves it, silence rarely does.

If a title is removed

KDP notifies you and you can appeal. The appeal is strongest when you can show the work is your own, that any AI-generated content was disclosed, and that the listing matches the book. Keep your drafts, your editing history and, where relevant, your AI-disclosure decisions, so you can prove your position if you ever need to.

Two habits keep an account safe over a long catalogue. First, keep a simple record for every book: what it is, who wrote what, what was disclosed, and where the source files live. Second, when KDP emails you, treat it as urgent. A suspended account is not just a lost book; it is a lost royalty stream and, sometimes, a lost catalogue.

Chapter 13

Your 60-day plan from zero to first royalty

This is the whole book compressed into a sequence you can follow without deciding anything from scratch. Sixty days is enough to research a niche, produce a real book, publish it and see your first sales, if you work in the right order.

When	What you do	Where in this book
Days 1-5	Choose the market (global English, Indian English or an Indian language). Run the niche scorecard on three candidates and pick one	Ch 6
Days 6-10	Research the top sellers in the niche: ranks, autocomplete phrases, and the complaints in their reviews. Lock the promise of your book	Ch 6, 9
Days 11-35	Write and edit the book. Research and outline with AI if you like; write the book yourself; disclose anything a machine wrote	Ch 7
Days 36-40	Decide the ISBN route. If you need an Indian ISBN, apply now (it takes about 7-9 working days)	Ch 5
Days 41-45	Produce the files: format the manuscript, build the cover to spec, check the pre-upload list	Ch 8
Days 46-48	Set up payment and the tax interview; enter your bank details and PAN	Ch 3, 4
Days 49-52	Fill in the listing: title, seven keywords, three categories, description. Set the price inside the 70% band	Ch 9, 10
Days 53-55	Upload, preview on phone, tablet and e-reader, and publish	Ch 8
Days 56-60	Launch: a short free promotion or Countdown Deal where available, a small ad campaign, and start book two	Ch 11

The one thing that decides whether this works

Consistency beats intensity. One book published and then abandoned earns pocket money. Three books published in a year, each aimed at the same reader, start to compound. The plan above is a loop, not a one-off: after day 60, go back to day 1 for the next title.

Chapter 14

Ten mistakes that cost Indian authors money

These are the errors that show up again and again in the accounts of Indian authors, and each one is preventable. Read this list before you publish, and again before you price your second book.

1. Pricing outside the 70% band

A Rs. 89 or Rs. 699 eBook drops you to 35%. Price inside Rs. 99 to Rs. 599 and, in India, enrol in KDP Select.

2. Forgetting the India KDP Select condition

In India the 70% rate requires KDP Select. An author who refuses exclusivity for a book that sells only in India has chosen 35% by accident.

3. Leaving the W-8BEN at 30%

If you never claim the India treaty, Amazon withholds 30% instead of 15% on US sales. It is a five-minute interview you complete once.

4. Letting the W-8BEN expire

The form lapses after the third calendar year. On expiry you silently revert to 30% until you redo it.

5. A fat eBook file

At Rs. 7 per MB of delivery cost, a bloated 12 MB file loses you about Rs. 84 a sale. Compress your images.

6. Undeclared AI-generated content

Text, images or translations a tool created must be disclosed, even after heavy editing. Silence here risks the account, not just the book.

7. A thin or rushed book

Very short, repetitive or poorly translated content is removable as a poor customer experience. Length must come from substance.

8. Chasing reviews the wrong way

Paid, swapped or incentivised reviews get accounts suspended. Let reviews accumulate honestly.

9. Planning around a print edition for India

KDP does not distribute print on Amazon.in. If your launch depends on an Indian reader buying a paperback, it will not work.

10. Publishing one book and stopping

The income comes from a catalogue, not a title. The second book is what makes the first one worth having written.

Chapter 15

Quick reference, FAQ and glossary

The India KDP fact sheet

Item	The figure	Where to confirm
India 70% royalty band	Rs. 99 - Rs. 599	KDP eBook List Price Requirements
India 70% condition	Must be enrolled in KDP Select	KDP Digital Book Pricing Page
Delivery cost, India, 70%	Rs. 7 per MB (min Rs. 1)	KDP Digital Book Pricing Page
GST inside an Indian list price	18%	KDP GST help page
Amazon.in withholding	10% (Singapore)	KDP Tax Withholding
Amazon.com withholding, India treaty	15% (else 30%)	KDP Tax Withholding; IRS treaty table
Royalty payment schedule	About 60 days after month end	Your KDP account
Minimum payout threshold	About USD 100 for bank transfer	Your KDP account
Indian ISBN	Free, via RRRNA (isbn.gov.in)	isbn.gov.in
Section 151 author deduction	Up to Rs. 3,00,000, old regime	Income-tax Act 2025, Section 151
Form for the deduction	Form 36 (Rule 70)	incometaxindia.gov.in
Foreign tax credit form	Form 67	incometaxindia.gov.in
GST threshold on India sales	Rs. 20 lakh aggregate turnover	CGST Act, Section 22
Cover, ideal	1600 x 2560 px, RGB, under 50 MB	KDP cover criteria
Keywords / categories	7 keywords, 3 categories	KDP metadata guidelines
Description limit	4,000 characters incl. HTML	KDP metadata guidelines
KDP print on Amazon.in	Not supported	KDP print help pages

Frequently asked questions

Do I need a company or GST to start?
No. You can publish as an individual using your PAN and your own bank account. A company and GST registration are questions for later, once your India sales approach the Rs. 20 lakh GST threshold or your income is large enough to warrant structuring.

Can I publish from India without a US bank account?
Yes. Amazon pays Indian authors by direct bank transfer to an Indian account. You complete a tax interview and give your PAN; you do not need a US account or PayPal.

Why does my US withholding show 30%?
Because you have not claimed the treaty benefit, or your W-8BEN has expired. Complete the tax interview, select India and treaty benefits, and enter your PAN. The rate then drops to 15% on US-source royalties.

Will Amazon withhold tax on my Amazon.in sales too?
Yes - a separate 10% Singaporean withholding applies to Amazon.in royalties for publishers not based in Singapore, and Indian authors are generally not eligible for a reduced rate. It is different from the US withholding and a W-8BEN does not change it.

How long before I get paid?	KDP pays on a cycle of roughly 60 days after the end of the sales month, once your balance crosses the minimum payout threshold, which is about USD 100 for bank transfer. Confirm the current figures in your account.
Is a paperback sold in India through KDP?	No. KDP does not support paperback or hardcover distribution on Amazon.in. Indian readers cannot buy your KDP print edition on the India store. Use an Indian printer and an Indian ISBN if you want a print edition in India.
Do I have to disclose AI-written content?	Yes, if a tool created the text, images or translations, even after substantial editing. AI-assisted content - where you wrote it and a tool polished or checked it - does not need disclosure.
Can I sell the same eBook on my own website?	Only if it is not in KDP Select. Select requires the digital edition to be exclusive to Amazon for the term. In India, the 70% royalty rate requires Select, so exclusivity is effectively the price of the higher rate.
How much can I realistically earn?	Most first books earn little. Income compounds through a catalogue: roughly, books x average sales per book per month x royalty per sale. At about Rs. 140 of royalty per sale, 12 books selling 5 copies a month each is around Rs. 8,400 a month.
Is this tax advice?	No. This playbook states the rules and where they live. Your own tax position depends on your facts. Speak to a chartered accountant before you file.

Glossary

Term	What it means
KDP	Kindle Direct Publishing - Amazon's self-publishing platform
KDP Select	A free 90-day exclusivity programme for Kindle eBooks; required for the 70% rate in India
Kindle Unlimited (KU)	Amazon's subscription library; KDP Select titles are included and earn per page read
KENPC	Kindle Edition Normalized Page Count - Amazon's standard page measure used to pay KU reads
Royalty band	The price range within which the 70% royalty option is available (Rs. 99-Rs. 599 in India)
List price	The retail price a reader pays; in India it already includes 18% GST
Delivery cost	A per-megabyte deduction from the 70% royalty, based on file size (Rs. 7/MB on Amazon.in)
W-8BEN	The US tax form a non-US author completes to claim a reduced treaty withholding rate
Withholding	Tax deducted at source before a royalty is paid (15% US on Amazon.com; 10% Singapore on Amazon.in)
ISBN	The 13-digit identifier for a book edition; free from KDP or from India's RRRNA
Section 151	The Income-tax Act 2025 provision allowing a resident author a deduction up to Rs. 3,00,000
Form 36	The certificate you file to claim the Section 151 author deduction
Form 67	The form you file to claim foreign tax credit for US tax already withheld

Sources

Sources

Every figure in this playbook was taken from an official source and is dated where it can move. Confirm the live number before it costs you.

What it covers	Official source
Royalty options, India band, delivery cost, KDP Select	Amazon KDP Help Centre - Digital Book Pricing Page and eBook List Price Requirements (kdp.amazon.com)
Withholding tax by marketplace, W-8BEN, treaty rate	Amazon KDP Help Centre - Tax Withholding and Tax Information
Kindle Unlimited per-page payouts and KENPC	Amazon KDP Help Centre - Royalties in Kindle Unlimited
AI content disclosure and content quality rules	Amazon KDP Help Centre - Content Guidelines
Metadata, keywords, categories, description rules	Amazon KDP Help Centre - Metadata Guidelines and Keywords
Cover specifications and manuscript formats	Amazon KDP Help Centre - cover image criteria and supported formats
Indian ISBN, process and timings	Raja Rammohun Roy National Agency for ISBN, Ministry of Education (isbn.gov.in)
Author royalty deduction, Rs. 3,00,000	Income-tax Act, 2025, Section 151 (formerly Section 80QQB)
Form 36 for the deduction	Income Tax Department - Form 36 FAQs and guidance note (incometaxindia.gov.in)
Foreign tax credit	Income Tax Department - Form 67; India-US treaty, Article 25
GST on domestic and exported digital sales	CGST Act, 2017, Sections 22 and 24; GST Council guidance

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